
Inaugural AUSTIN NEWSLETTER THING

Austin Todd <austinttodd@gmail.com>

Fri, Dec 27, 2024 at 12:52 PM

Blog 12/2024

Hello friends, wherever you are!

I'm starting this little blog/newsletter because i saw Meg do it and Alan do it and i want to steal their good idea. I've gotten more interested in using Instagram as a way to genuinely share with people where i'm at and what i'm doing, but socials have their limits, and there was something exhilarating about receiving Meg's newsletter in my inbox a few weeks back.

The thing i like least about the newsletter/blog (or worse, substack) format is its one directionality. So, if you'd like, feel free to write back, even if it's just a small thought or comment or question! The more of a dialogue this is, the more fun it will be, i think.

Since the 11th, i've been back in Arkansas. I said goodbye to friends in Alaska, sold nearly all of the pottery i made during the fall semester and raised just over \$1700 for mutual aid and for Mayar's family in Gaza. Also, i finally got around to making fish head soup with the salmon i'd frozen from this summer. It was TASTY. Here's a photo:



Arkansas is quiet. I worked remotely for the first week and a half i was here, but now i'm done, the only thing left is to onboard my replacement in January. I've been reading and trying to finish editing the music video Sarah and the gang and I made. Also in January, i'm going to become an uncle (unless the baby comes early). As the date approaches i find myself both looking forward to it and thinking i'll greet the baby with a touch of grief given the world she is being born into, what she will have to learn, unlearn.

In what feels like a big step for me but is realistically not that huge, i've been taking a break from caffeine. I don't think i've taken a break from caffeine since i started drinking coffee at 16 or 17. It's been about a week sans caffeine. I went to the doctor and my heart's fine, which was a relief (i was

worried about post-covid complications), but i'm still going to give it a month or so on very limited caffeine. Surprisingly, i don't feel like rushing back to my twice-a-day coffees. Without them at first i felt almost like a different person, or as if i had a clearer perspective on myself. Like my brain downloaded some new fonts to think in. At the same time, i feel sleepy. But sleepiness, too, is a blessing of sorts, just like boredom, maybe. For the first time in six years i can take a nap any i feel like it. In any case, it's lucky that this caffeine holiday coincides with work holidays.

[cw: this paragraph has some mentions of violent rhetoric]

I nearly made it through the holidays without breaking down, but on the 25th my parents and i took a meal to my father's stepmother's brother, Leon, and i lost my hold on things a bit. Leon lives alone since his wife died and is wheelchair-bound. His apartment was fairly neat: a large bookshelf filled with bibles and biblical commentaries abutted a wide desk, on which he kept various papers, more bibles and biblical atlases, some sound equipment, and a desktop computer quietly playing gospel music. He told us how he built that bookshelf out of scraps leftover from doing the interior on Don Tyson's oval office, probably 40 years ago. The Tysons had gone to D.C., took measurements of the Oval Office, and made three replicas for their corporate headquarters in Springdale. Leon seems alert for his age—his greenish eyes feel both piercing and not-seeing, and he has a habit of slowly inching forward in his wheelchair when speaking. He loves complimenting his late wife but does so in a somehow sexist way. Anyway, him and my father got to discussing EVs, which led to Biden, which led to Biden's recent Federal pardons. Earlier Leon had given us some fruit cake and i noticed letters on his kitchen table from Friends of Zion, "Israel is Under Attack!" printed on the envelopes. Him and my father went back and forth, one saying "if I had my way" people convicted of such-and-such crime "would be hanged in the square," the other saying "there should be 30 days to appeal, and then they serve their sentence," and so on. The bloodlust was making me sick. Leon kept scooting his wheelchair closer and closer to my mom, who sat silently. I brought up the passage where Jesus tells the man being crucified next to him "I will see you in heaven." This pushed the two to new heights of doublethink and stupidity. Later, in the car, my feeling of nausea subsided. My father drove to the jail where he has worked the past few years and took cookies to the jailer. My heart kept skipping beats in the backseat.

The next section has some blabber about what i've been reading, and then lastly i put in a bit about the local coffee shop "Onyx Coffee Lab" because, as many of you know, my slight obsession with that place resurfaces every time i'm in Arkansas. I'm thinking about eventually distilling the material i have enough to pitch it to (it's a dream, i know) $n+1$. It feels like the kind of weird, sustained piece they'd maybe take. I've also been pondering reworking old undergrad Tawada work (translations/thesis) for publication somewhere. Feeling like publishing is possible after seeing Isa's recent academic piece! Are y'all working on anything? Picking up old threads? Having weird, disturbing interactions with distant family members?

WHAT IM READING/WATCHING LATELY

- *The Dispossessed*, Ursula Le Guin
 - o This book genuinely shifted how i think about property, ownership, sharing, and giving. As I was packing to leave Alaska, i'd stop and look at some possession or other with a new, odd awareness that there is nothing material that makes it "my property." Like when you repeat a word over and over until stops making sense. Thanks to Gracie for *sharing* the book with me. Le Guin's rigorous imagining of functioning anarchist society really makes you look more radically at our own present.
- *Sabbath as resistance*, Walter Brueggemann
 - o I've been on a little journey reinterpreting the religion (Evangelical Christianity) i was raised in. I heard of Brueggemann from the poet Pádraig Ó Tuama, in his talks on "Strange Stories of the Bible" (which were also excellent). This book was the only one the Springdale Public Library had, and in it, Brueggemann articulates sabbath as a radical divestment from commodity consumption/production. If sabbath is

restfulness, then its opposite is restlessness. Once again, the bible's radical side drawn out by a sharp analysis...

- *History of Love*, Nicole Krauss
 - o Very smoothly and intelligently written, only complaint was how overplayed romantic love is.
- *Greek Lessons*, Han Kang
 - o Loved the ruminations on language, and feel the novel, while concept-driven, successfully characterizes those populating it, something I can't say of similar fiction by Calvino or Tawada.
- *Teaching critical thinking*, hooks (in progress)
 - o So many good learnings. Biggest shift so far is that deference in the classroom isn't necessarily domination: "To honor a teacher with reverence does not require subordination. In a democratic society where there is so much emphasis on equality, there is a tendency to forget that inequality does not necessarily mean domination is taking place" (114). 🍷
- Haven't been watching many films. Would love any recs. In particular want to look into Syrian films—Anchorage for Palestine is wanting to screen some in January
- Jane Remover and Olivia Dean's shows on NTS
- [These](#) poems by Rita Dove (thank you Anya for sharing):

o

SONNET

Nothing can console me. You may bring silk
to make skin sigh, dispense yellow roses
in the manner of ripened dignitaries.
You can tell me repeatedly
I am unbearable (and I know this):
still, nothing turns the gold to corn,
nothing is sweet to the teeth crushing it.

I'll not ask for the impossible;
one learns to walk by walking.
In time I'll forget this empty brimming.
I may laugh again at
a bird, perhaps, chucking the nest—
but it will not be happiness,
for I have known that.

PROTECTION

Are you having a good time?
Are you having a time at all?
Everywhere in the garden I see the slim vine
of your neck, the stubborn baby curls—

I know I'm not saying this right.
"Good" hair has no body
in this country; like trained ivy,
it hangs and shines. Mine comes out

in clusters. Is there such
a thing as a warning? The Hawaian
mulberry is turning to ash

and the snail has lost its home.
Are you really all over with? How done
is gone?

- o Noticed more this time around in "Sonnet" how the consolations the speaker is offered are not gestural (like a hug) or words, but commodities: "silk / to make skin sigh" and "yellow roses / in the manner of ripened dignitaries." There's also "gold" and something "sweet." Grief here is not a rejection of all consolation, forever. The speaker imagines laughing in the future at "a bird, perhaps, chucking the nest". But commodity and comfort will bring neither happiness nor consolation.

ONYX COFFEE REPORT

My thoughts this month about Onyx were spurred by an [article](#) about digital surveillance by Zoë Hitzig. This quote in particular:

In her 2015 book *In Defense of Secrets*, the late French psychoanalyst Anne Dufourmantelle corrects one of the implicit claims of the surveillance-as-intimacy perspective: "Transparency is not

truth," she writes.

The essay as a whole argues that big tech has hoodwinked us into seeing surveillance "as a form of intimacy." Being on someone's Find My is a badge of closeness; BeReal catches us in candid moments. However, "the sense that we are showing less filtered and more continuous footage of our lives to our friends distracts us from the reality that we are also showing all of it to the extraordinarily powerful tech companies that gave us the idea to do so in the first place."

The transparency-is-not-truth quote comes as Hitzig considers how unmediated digital access to friends and partners' lives can warp these relationships. Surveillance leaves no opportunity for trust or to see each other as autonomous individuals with the right to secrets! The "true" friend is not the one you know everything about: where they've been, who they've talked to, etc. The "true" friend is the one right in front of you, whose depths you can never fully know.

Onyx Coffee Lab prides themselves on being transparent. One place this manifests is their price breakdowns. They publish how much they paid for a coffee, how much went to shipping, importers, and roasting. Another site of transparency, though, is their packaging. Each coffee or tea box has a paragraph long description of its origin. The question I am asking is: in the face of all this information, where is the truth? Or is this just a surveillance logic calculated to generate yet another faux intimacy?

Okay that's all for this month! Looking forward to hearing from folks. What are you strangely obsessed with these days? What troubles you? What consoles you?

<3
austin



Sliman Mansour, "The way to Bethlehem"